Zero Trust Architecture for Securing PLC–HMI Communication in Industrial Control Systems: mTLS-Based Proxy Design, Policy Enforcement, and Empirical Attack Validation

***Abstract*—Legacy industrial communication protocols—Modbus TCP in particular—operate without native authentication, encryption, or integrity verification, leaving programmable logic controllers (PLCs) exposed to unauthorized command injection on any co-located network segment. This paper presents a deployable Zero Trust Architecture (ZTA) for the PLC-to-HMI communication channel that requires no firmware changes to existing field devices. The proposed system interposes a Python-based transparent proxy between the human-machine interface (HMI) and the PLC, enforcing mutual Transport Layer Security (mTLS) with X.509 certificate authentication on the HMI-facing port while forwarding only policy-compliant Modbus application data units (ADUs) to the controller. A deterministic function-code policy engine blocks all write-class function codes (FC05, FC06, FC0F, FC10) and permits only read operations (FC01–FC04), eliminating the write-injection surface without relying on anomaly detection. Five attack categories—unauthorized coil writes, sensor register spoofing, supply depletion denial-of-service, combined multi-vector disruption, and session replay—are executed against a hardware-in-the-loop testbed running OpenPLC Runtime on Ubuntu 22.04 LTS with an IEC 61131-3 Structured Text water distribution control program. All five attack classes are completely blocked in the ZTA-enabled configuration, while the unprotected baseline registers a 100% success rate for each. Mean per-transaction latency increases by 2.3 ms (from 1.4 ms to 3.7 ms), and system availability over a 14,400-cycle observation window is 98.6%. The testbed, certificate infrastructure, and attack scripts are open-source, providing a reproducible validation platform for future OT security research.**

***Index Terms*—Zero Trust Architecture, Industrial Control Systems, Modbus TCP, Mutual TLS, PLC Security, IT/OT Convergence**

I. Introduction

Operational technology (OT) networks that govern physical processes—water treatment, power generation, chemical processing—were engineered for determinism and availability, not confidentiality or authentication. The Modbus application protocol, ratified in 1979 for serial communication over RS-232, remains deployed in an estimated 90% of installed industrial automation infrastructure globally [1]. Its Ethernet adaptation, Modbus TCP, preserves the original protocol's application-layer structure: a six-byte MBAP header followed by a one-byte function code and variable data payload, with no provision for peer authentication, session keying, or message integrity [2].

The practical consequence is well-documented. Any host reaching port 502/TCP on a PLC can issue arbitrary read or write commands without credentials, alter coil outputs, overwrite register values, or inject fabricated sensor readings that the HMI cannot distinguish from legitimate telemetry [3]. The 2021 Oldsmar water treatment incident demonstrated this exposure concretely: an unauthenticated remote desktop session provided direct HMI access through which a sodium hydroxide setpoint was raised to 111 times the safe level [4]. Prior events in the Ukrainian power grid (2015, 2016) used compromised HMI stations to dispatch authenticated-looking Modbus and DNP3 commands that de-energized substations serving 230,000 consumers [5].

A. Limitations of Existing Approaches

Network-layer segmentation and VLAN isolation reduce the attack surface but do not address the case of a compromised authorized host or an insider threat: an HMI workstation already possessing firewall permission can still issue unrestricted write commands [6]. Anomaly-detection approaches—including machine learning classifiers applied to Modbus traffic [7]—achieve high detection rates for known patterns but cannot block zero-day write injections deterministically, and false positives in process-control contexts carry significant operational cost [8]. Protocol replacement (e.g., OPC-UA with Security Mode *SignAndEncrypt*) provides native session authentication and encryption but demands firmware upgrades or gateway hardware on every field device, a cost often prohibitive for brownfield facilities with PLCs installed before the year 2000 [9]. Commercial inline security appliances (e.g., Tofino, Claroty) implement function-code filtering but typically lack per-identity access control and carry capital costs of USD 3,000–15,000 per choke point [10].

B. Contributions

This paper makes the following specific contributions:

1) A non-intrusive ZTA proxy architecture that enforces mTLS mutual authentication and application-layer write-blocking on any Modbus TCP-speaking PLC, requiring zero changes to controller firmware or HMI application software.

2) A deterministic function-code policy engine with formally bounded decision latency, contrasted against probabilistic anomaly-detection alternatives.
3) Empirical validation across five distinct attack categories on a functional IEC 61131-3 testbed, with quantified latency overhead and availability measurements.
4) A fully reproducible open-source testbed—certificates, PLC program, proxy, attack scripts—to support independent replication and extension.

II. Related Work

A. ICS Attack Taxonomy and Threat Modeling

Cardenas *et al.* [21] established a formal taxonomy of ICS-targeted attacks categorized as denial-of-service (DoS), integrity attacks, and replay attacks, each exploiting the absence of application-layer authentication in legacy protocols. Amin *et al.* [3] demonstrated through formal analysis that partial sensor data manipulation in water distribution systems can remain undetected by standard supervisory thresholds for extended intervals. McLaughlin *et al.* [22] analyzed control-logic injection as a distinct class, showing that an attacker with write access to holding registers can corrupt PLC scan-cycle behavior without generating network-level anomalies.

B. Zero Trust Architecture

The ZTA framework formalized in NIST SP 800-207 [11] specifies seven tenets, of which identity-centric per-session access control and continuous monitoring are most applicable to OT communication paths. Gilchrist [12] mapped ZTA principles to industrial IoT environments conceptually but without functional implementation or latency measurement. Nguyen *et al.* [13] implemented a software-defined perimeter for SCADA protection, reporting handshake overheads of 8–15 ms, which can be prohibitive for sub-second control loops. The present work reduces this overhead to a mean of 2.3 ms through a single-process proxy design that avoids the inter-service communication latency inherent in microservice-based ZTA implementations.

C. Modbus Protocol Security

Huitsing *et al.* [2] proposed a Modbus intrusion detection system based on function-code whitelisting but did not combine detection with authenticated session enforcement, leaving the system susceptible to attacks from authorized-but-compromised hosts. Fovino *et al.* [14] extended this approach with a Modbus/DNP3 firewall implementing rate limiting and address-range constraints, achieving measurable intrusion reduction without encryption. Carcano *et al.* [15] introduced state-based anomaly detection for ICS protocols, demonstrating that multidimensional process-state models detect stealthy attacks that single-metric approaches miss. None of these prior works combines mutual certificate authentication with deterministic function-code policy enforcement in a single transparent proxy, which is the distinguishing characteristic of the present design.

D. TLS in OT Environments

IEC 62443-3-3 [16] specifies Security Level 2 requirements that include session authentication and encrypted data channels for ICS communication. Stouffer *et al.* [17] discuss transport-layer encryption as a compensating control for legacy protocol deficiencies. Kabir *et al.* [18] evaluated TLS 1.3 performance on ARM Cortex-M microcontrollers representative of embedded HMI hardware, reporting acceptable overheads for slow-loop process control when session resumption is employed. Beck *et al.* [19] specifically evaluated mTLS for MQTT-based IIoT telemetry, documenting a 1.8–3.1 ms per-message overhead on resource-constrained nodes. The present work reports consistent figures (mean 2.3 ms) on commodity x86 Linux hardware operating at the Modbus TCP layer.

III. System Architecture and Methodology

A. Testbed Overview

The experimental system models a water distribution process in which a main supply tank of capacity $C_M = 400$ units feeds three sub-tanks, each with capacity $C_i = 100$ units ($i \in \{1, 2, 3\}$), through independently controlled binary valves V_i. The PLC program, compiled and executed by OpenPLC Runtime v3.0 under IEC 61131-3 Structured Text, implements the following fill-control policy at scan interval $T_s = 500$ ms:

$$V_i(t) = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if } L_i(t) < L_{\text{th}} \text{ and } L_M(t) > 0 \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \tag{1}$$

where $L_i(t)$ denotes the level of sub-tank i at scan cycle t, $L_M(t)$ is the main tank level, and $L_{\text{th}} = 80$ units. Fluid transfer is modeled at a nominal rate of $\dot{q} = 0.4$ units per 100 ms rendering cycle. Variable-to-Modbus address mapping, generated by OpenPLC's `glue_generator` pass, assigns:

$$L_i \mapsto \text{Holding Register } \texttt{QW}i, \quad i \in \{1, 2, 3\} \tag{2}$$

$$L_M \mapsto \text{Holding Register } \texttt{QW}10 \tag{3}$$

$$V_i \mapsto \text{Coil } \texttt{QX0}.i, \quad i \in \{0, 1, 2\} \tag{4}$$

B. Threat Model

The adversary is modeled as a host with TCP/IP reachability to the OT network segment, possessing knowledge of the Modbus TCP protocol structure and the PLC's register map, and equipped with standard penetration-testing tools including pymodbus 3.6.9 and Scapy. Physical access, firmware exploitation, and operating-system zero-days are outside scope. Five threat scenarios are enumerated in Table I, mapped to the STRIDE framework [23].

C. Zero Trust Proxy Design

The ZTA proxy operates as a multi-threaded Python server bound to port 5020. Per-connection processing follows the pipeline in Algorithm 1.
The policy sets are defined as:

$$\mathcal{F}_{\text{allow}} = \{0x01,\ 0x02,\ 0x03,\ 0x04\} \tag{5}$$

$$\mathcal{F}_{\text{block}} = \{0x05,\ 0x06,\ 0x0F,\ 0x10\} \tag{6}$$

TABLE I
ATTACK SCENARIOS AND STRIDE CLASSIFICATION

ID	Attack	Target	FC	STRIDE
A1	Valve force	Coils QX0.0–2	0x05	Tampering
A2	Sensor spoof	Regs QW1–3	0x10	Tampering
A3	Supply drain	Reg QW10	0x06	DoS
A4	Multi-vector	All registers	Multiple	T + DoS
A5	Replay	Comm. channel	Any	Repudiation



Fig. 1. System architecture. The ZT proxy interposes between HMI (port 5020, mTLS) and PLC (port 502, plaintext). Direct port-502 access is restricted by host firewall rules.

Policy evaluation at line 10 constitutes a Python `dict` lookup with $O(1)$ complexity, contributing a worst-case deterministic overhead of $\Delta t_{\text{policy}} < 50$ µs.

D. PKI and Certificate Infrastructure

A three-tier PKI is established using OpenSSL 3.0.2. The root CA is generated with a 2048-bit RSA key and 3650-day validity. Component certificates—one for the proxy server (`CN=PLC-Server`) and one for each authorized HMI client (`CN=HMI-Client`)—are issued with CA signatures. The proxy SSL context enforces:

- `ssl.PROTOCOL_TLS_SERVER` with minimum version TLS 1.2
- `verify_mode = ssl.CERT_REQUIRED`
- CA certificate loaded for peer verification

The TLS handshake employs ECDHE key exchange, providing forward secrecy: session keys are ephemeral and derived independently for each connection, rendering captured ciphertext undecipherable even if a long-term private key is subsequently compromised [20].

Algorithm 1 ZTA Proxy Connection Handler

Require: Incoming TCP connection c on port 5020
1: Perform TLS handshake with `CERT_REQUIRED` mode
2: **if** handshake fails **then**
3: Log REJECTED(c.addr, SSLERROR)
4: Close c; **return**
5: **end if**
6: Extract $identity \leftarrow c.\text{cert}[\textit{subject}][\text{CN}]$
7: Open raw TCP socket s to `127.0.0.1 : 502`
8: **while** c is open **do**
9: $pdu \leftarrow \texttt{recv}(c, 1024)$
10: $fc \leftarrow pdu[7]$
11: **if** $fc \in \mathcal{F}_{\text{allow}}$ **then**
12: Log ALLOWED($identity$, fc)
13: $\texttt{send}(s, pdu)$; forward reply to c
14: **else if** $fc \in \mathcal{F}_{\text{block}}$ **then**
15: Log BLOCKED($identity$, fc)
16: Send Modbus exception (0x80 — fc, code 0x01) to c
17: **end if**
18: **end while**

IV. EXPERIMENTAL SETUP AND RESULTS

A. Test Environment

All experiments execute on a single Oracle VirtualBox 7.0 VM allocated 4 GB RAM and 2 CPU cores (Intel Core i5-10th-generation host), running Ubuntu 22.04 LTS (kernel 6.5.0). Table II summarizes the software stack.

TABLE II
EXPERIMENTAL SOFTWARE STACK

Component	Software	Version
PLC runtime	OpenPLC Runtime v3	3.0 (2024)
PLC language	Structured Text	IEC 61131-3
HMI	Node-RED	4.1.7
SCADA dashboard	HTML5/WebSocket	Custom
Modbus client	pymodbus	3.6.9
ZT proxy	Python `ssl`/`socket`	3.12
PKI	OpenSSL	3.0.2
Packet capture	Wireshark/tshark	4.2.5
OS	Ubuntu 22.04 LTS	Kernel 6.5

B. Baseline: Unprotected Modbus TCP

Wireshark captures on the loopback interface (`lo`) with display filter `modbus` confirm that all Modbus ADUs—function codes, register addresses, and payload values—are transmitted in cleartext. During a representative 4-hour observation window, 185,690 total packets were captured, of which 74,896 were classified as Modbus/TCP frames. Three concurrent clients (Node-RED HMI, SCADA bridge, monitoring script) each maintaining persistent TCP connections to port 502 were individually indistinguishable at the network layer.

All five attack scripts executed successfully against the unprotected configuration. Attack A1 forced all coil outputs to

the attacker-specified state within a single Modbus transaction (<5 ms round-trip). Attack A2 overwrote holding registers QW1–3 with arbitrary values; the HMI displayed injected readings as authoritative telemetry. Attack A3 set register QW10 to zero, satisfying the condition $L_M(t) \leq 0$ in (1) and halting all valve actuation. Attack A4 chained A2, A1, and A3 in sequence within 2.4 s. Attack A5 replayed a raw Modbus TCP packet captured via Scapy directly to port 502 using a raw Python socket; the PLC executed the replayed command on all four re-transmission attempts.

C. ZTA-Protected Configuration

TABLE III
ATTACK OUTCOMES: BASELINE VS. ZTA-ENABLED

ID	Attack	Baseline	ZTA	Block Point
A1	Valve force	Success	Blocked	FC05 policy
A2	Sensor spoof	Success	Blocked	FC10 policy
A3	Supply drain	Success	Blocked	FC06 policy
A4	Multi-vector	Success	Blocked	All FC policy
A5	Replay	Success	Blocked	TLS seq. no.

Table III reports a 100% block rate across all attack classes. Attacks without a CA-signed client certificate are rejected at the TLS handshake layer before any Modbus byte is transmitted to the PLC; no byte reaches port 502 for unauthenticated connections. Attacks using a valid stolen certificate (A1–A4, re-run with `hmi.crt`) are blocked at the policy-engine layer: function codes in $\mathcal{F}_{\text{block}}$ receive a Modbus exception response from the proxy, and the controller receives no data. Attack A5 fails because TLS session keys are ephemeral; a ciphertext captured from a prior session cannot be decrypted or injected into a new session with distinct ECDHE key material.

With ZTA enabled, applying the Wireshark filter `modbus` to the loopback interface yields zero decoded frames; traffic appears exclusively as TLS Application Data records. This confirms that network-resident capture yields no actionable Modbus intelligence.

D. Latency and Availability

Transaction latency was measured across $n = 1{,}000$ FC03 Read Holding Registers requests using Python's `time.perf_counter()` at microsecond resolution. Table IV presents the statistical summary.

TABLE IV
MODBUS TRANSACTION LATENCY ($n = 1000$, FC03, 4 REGISTERS)

Metric	Baseline (ms)	ZTA (ms)	Δ (ms)
Mean	1.4	3.7	+2.3
Median	1.2	3.3	+2.1
95th percentile	2.1	5.8	+3.7
99th percentile	3.4	8.2	+4.8
Maximum	12.3	19.7	+7.4

The mean overhead of 2.3 ms decomposes as: TLS record encryption/decryption (≈1.1 ms), Python socket handling (≈0.7 ms), and Modbus ADU parsing (≈0.5 ms). For the water-distribution control loop executing at $T_s = 500$ ms, this overhead represents 0.46% of the scan interval and is operationally negligible. The overhead is consistent with results reported for mTLS on resource-constrained nodes by Beck *et al.* [19].

System availability, defined as the proportion of 1-Hz HMI poll cycles receiving a valid Modbus response within a 1-second timeout, was 98.6% over the 14,400-cycle observation window. Of 14 timeout events recorded, 11 were attributable to Python garbage-collection pauses in the proxy process and 3 to VM scheduling jitter; no timeout was attributable to ZTA security processing.

E. Comparative Analysis

Table V positions the proposed approach against representative prior-art solutions across security, performance, and deployment dimensions.

TABLE V
COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS OF ICS SECURITY APPROACHES

Approach	Auth.	Enc.	FC Policy	PLC Chg.	Cost
This work	mTLS	Yes	Per-ID	None	Free
VPN only	Device	Yes	No	None	Low
IP firewall	IP addr	No	No	None	Low
Comm. FW [2]	None	No	Global	None	High
OPC-UA [9]	Cert	Yes	App-layer	Full	Very high

V. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

A Zero Trust proxy architecture for Modbus TCP has been designed, implemented, and empirically evaluated against five attack categories. The system achieves a 100% block rate across all tested threats while introducing a mean latency overhead of 2.3 ms—negligible for the slow-loop process control applications that constitute the majority of deployed ICS infrastructure. The retrofit-compatible design, requiring no changes to PLC firmware or HMI application logic, provides a practical path for security hardening in brownfield OT environments.

Several directions warrant further investigation. First, a compiled proxy implementation in C or Rust could reduce the per-transaction overhead by an estimated 60%, making the approach viable for control loops with sub-100 ms scan intervals. Second, integrating the proxy audit logs with a security information and event management (SIEM) platform would enable cross-device correlation and detection of coordinated multi-PLC campaigns. Third, extending the policy engine with behavioral-baseline analytics would permit detection of anomalous read patterns—such as reconnaissance polling of atypical register ranges—from authenticated but compromised HMI clients. Finally, formal verification of the policy engine logic using model checking tools such as TLA$^+$ or SPIN

would provide machine-checked assurance that $\mathcal{F}_{\text{allow}}$ and $\mathcal{F}_{\text{block}}$ are disjoint and exhaustive.

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